WORLD WAR II

CHANNEL DASH 1942



Date February 11–13, 1942
Forces Germans: 2 battlecruisers, 1 heavy cruiser, 6 destroyers, 40 other vessels; British: 9 destroyers, 32 motor torpedo boats
Losses Germans: 17 aircraft; British: 42 aircraft
Location The English Channel

The German battlecruisers *Scharnhorst* and *Gneisenau* and the heavy cruiser *Prinz Eugen* were ordered to return to Germany from Brest through the Channel. Under Vice Admiral Otto Ciliax, they left port late on the night of February 11-12 and sailed 300 miles (480 km) down the Channel before they were detected, even though the British had been expecting their move. They dodged fire from shore guns and brushed off destroyers and torpedo boats. A gallant attack by six Fairey Swordfish biplanes led by Lieutenant Commander Eugene Esmond also failed and all the aircraft were shot down. Despite hitting a number of mines, the ships successfully reached home, to the great embarrassment of the Royal Navy.

ammunition, *Achilles* and *Ajax* settled for shadowing *Graf Spee* through the day, largely succeeding in keeping out of range of the battleship's guns. That night, *Graf Spee* entered the port of Montevideo, the capital of neutral Uruguay. According to the rules of war, the Uruguayans had to order the German warship to leave after repairs or intern both the ship and its crew. British misinformation convinced Langsdorff that a powerful Royal Navy force awaited him—while in fact only the heavy cruiser *Cumberland* had joined *Ajax* and *Achilles*. Langsdorff rejected the options of internment or a showdown. On December 17 *Graf Spee* steamed out into the River Plate estuary, the crew were taken off, and the ship was scuttled. Two days later, Langsdorff shot himself.

Ajax and Achilles
The light cruiser *Achilles* seen from underneath the guns of her sister ship *Ajax* after battle with *Graf Spee*. The guns are loaded and trained in the direction of the River Plate estuary to prevent *Graf Spee*'s escape.

WORLD WAR II

ATTACKS ON TIRPITZ

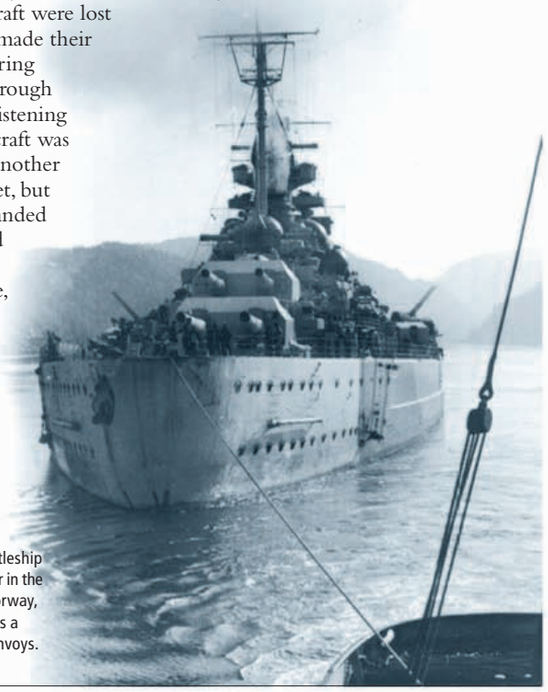


Date September 22, 1943; April 3,1944
Forces Germans: 1 pocket battleship; British: 6 submarines, 6 midget submarines, 6 fleet and escort carriers, 2 battleships, 2 cruisers, 16 destroyers
Losses Germans: none; British: 5 midget submarines, 3 aircraft
Location Kafjord and Altenfjord, Norway

From early 1942 the German pocket battleship *Tirpitz* was stationed in northern Norway, posing a threat to British Arctic convoys. The Royal Navy tried to sink *Tirpitz* in the fjords, twice inflicting serious damage. In September 1943 six X-craft—midget submarines with a three-man crew—were towed across the North Sea by conventional submarines. Two X-craft were lost en route but the rest made their run into Kafjord, steering a hazardous course through a minefield and past listening posts. One of the X-craft was sunk by gunfire and another failed to locate a target, but X-6 and X-7, commanded by Lieutenant Donald Cameron and Lieutenant Basil Place, succeeded in laying their explosive charges beneath *Tirpitz*'s hull. These exploded, causing substantial damage that put the ship out of action for six months. The crews of the X-craft survived but were captured. Cameron and Place received the Victoria Cross.

OPERATION TUNGSTEN

Another attack on *Tirpitz* was carried out by the Fleet Air Arm in April 1944. The fleet carriers *Victorious* and *Furious*, supported by a powerful force including two battleships, launched 40 Fairey Barracuda dive-bombers with fighter escorts in two waves. The fighters strafed *Tirpitz* and the Barracudas dropped both general-purpose and armor-piercing bombs, the latter disappointingly failing to penetrate the battleship's deck. *Tirpitz* suffered more than 400 casualties and was put out of action for a further month. She was finally sunk by the Royal Air Force on November 12, 1944.



Hidden menace
The huge Bismarck-class battleship *Tirpitz* spent much of the war in the fjords of German-occupied Norway, where her mere presence was a threat to the Allied Arctic convoys.

WORLD WAR II

NORTH CAPE 1943



Date December 26, 1943
Forces Germans: 1 battlecruiser; British: 1 battleship, 4 cruisers, 9 destroyers
Losses Germans: 1 battlecruiser; British: none
Location Off northern Norway

The German battlecruiser *Scharnhorst*, under Rear Admiral Erich Bey, sortied from its harbor in Norway, intending to attack British Arctic convoy JW-55B. The British were aware of *Scharnhorst*'s movements through signals intercepts and prepared to counterattack. Bey had dispersed his destroyer escorts to search for the convoy and the battlecruiser was alone when surprised by the cruisers *Sheffield*, *Belfast*, and *Norfolk* on the morning of December 26. The weather was bleak, with a heavy snowstorm in progress. The British cruisers scored two hits on *Scharnhorst*, disabling her forward radar and radar-assisted fire control. They then tracked the German warship while calling in support from a larger force commanded by Admiral Sir Bruce Fraser on board the battleship *Duke of York*, with the cruiser *Jamaica* and a bevy of destroyers.

A desperate pursuit developed, *Scharnhorst* running for Norway and exchanging salvoes with *Duke of York* at long range. The crucial moment came when a shell from the Royal Navy battleship destroyed one of *Scharnhorst*'s engine rooms, sharply reducing her speed. British (and one Norwegian) destroyers were then able to close for torpedo attacks. Despite taking some damage, the destroyers scored four hits. As star shells lit up the Arctic night, the crippled *Scharnhorst* was battered by the guns of *Duke of York* and the cruisers *Jamaica* and *Belfast*, then suffered multiple torpedo strikes as destroyers closed for the kill. She capsized and sank. Of her crew of 2,004 men, only 36 were rescued from the ice-cold sea.